

Comparison and Contrast

Showing Similarities and Differences

This is a sample comparison and contrast paragraph.

Both Superman and Batman are heroes, but only one is truly a superhero. *Upbringing was not gentle for either.* Superman came from Krypton, a planet that was about to self-destruct. His parents sent him on a spaceship to Earth. There he would be adopted by an ordinary farm family. In the same generation, far away in Gotham, Bruce Wayne, the future Batman, was born to a contented, wealthy family. Tragically, his parents were killed in his presence during a mugging. He inherited the family wealth and was raised by his kindly butler. *Those very different backgrounds provided Superman and Batman with powerful but different motives for fighting crime.* Superman was programmed in his space capsule to know about the forces of good and evil on Earth and to fight the bad people. Unlike Superman, Batman learned from experience. **Both have gone on to fight many bad people, but each one has a special enemy.** For Superman, it is Lex Luthor, who has studied Superman and knows all about him, even his outstanding weakness—the mineral Kryptonite. For Batman, it is the Joker, who, as a wicked teenager, was the mugger-murderer of his parents. Many spectacular battles have ensued for both crime fighters, and one has reached the top in his profession. **Most people would cheer Superman on, however, they would identify more with Batman, and he is the superhero.**

(From: Brandon & Brandon, 2011: 282-283)

Introductory Paragraph: Batman vs. Superman

During the Depression in the 1930s, Superman and Batman were created as the first big comic-book heroes. More than two thousand similar but lesser characters were to follow. Both Superman and Batman have been enormously successful, but one seems to have more personality and is probably closer to most of us emotionally. Which hero wins out in this struggle for our hearts and minds? Taking into account their upbringing, motives, and criminal targets, one can argue that it is Batman who is more credible.

Point-by-Point

For Essay

Introduction with thesis

I. Upbringing

A. Superman

B. Batman

II. Motives

A. Superman

B. Batman

III. Enemies

A. Superman

B. Batman

Conclusion

Block-by-Block

For Essay

Introduction with thesis

I. Superman

A. Upbringing

B. Motives

C. Enemies

II. Batman

A. Upbringing

B. Motives

C. Enemies

Conclusion

Writing the Thesis Statement

Thesis Statements for Comparison/Contrast

The topic sentence of a paragraph or the thesis of an essay should name the subjects (A and B) and announce the focus on contrast and/or comparison.

Examples: Weak Thesis Statements

- They are both somewhat alike and somewhat different.
- I can see some similarities and some differences too.
- Both of them involve (only a single similarity, no differences).

Examples: Better Thesis Statements

In order to make a decision between the Honda Civic and the BMW, we must consider the differences in price of the vehicle, average mileage, and price of insurance.

Paragraph Organization

--Point-by-Point--

	2 nd Paragraph	3 rd Paragraph	4 th Paragraph
	Price	Mileage	Insurance
BMW	↓ ↓	↓ ↓	↓ ↓
Honda Civic	↓ ↓	↓ ↓	↓ ↓

Point-by-Point Method – Essay Outline

I. Introduction

- a) Hook
- b) Background Information
- c) Thesis

II. Price

- a) BMW
- b) Honda

III. Mileage

- a) BMW
- b) Honda

IV. Insurance

- a) BMW
- b) Honda

IV. Conclusion

- a) Emphasize Major Ties
- b) So What? Evaluate
- c) Clincher

Rules of Thumb

- Be sure to discuss both subjects equally in terms of coverage.
- Be sure to discuss the same elements for each subject; do not discuss one element for one subject and not do so for the other!
- Decide either upon block or alternating arrangement; do not mix.
- Have a clear purpose to achieve in the comparison/contrast.

Transitions

To Compare

- also
- as
- in the same way
- like
- likewise
- similarly
- comparable
- equally
- in addition

To Contrast

- although
- but
- even though
- however
- on the other hand
- otherwise
- yet
- still
- conversely
- as opposed to
- different from
- whereas

Example

Thesis: The Caribe Hilton Hotel is better than the Ritz Carlton because of the location, the prices, and the service.

The first sentence of each body paragraph is called the **TOPIC SENTENCE**.

This sentence serves as an introduction to the paragraph and establishes its purpose. Look at these examples.

1. The Caribe Hilton Hotel is located in a much better **place** than its competitor, the Ritz Carlton.
2. The Caribe Hilton offers better **price** rates at all times.
3. You will receive a far better **service** at the Caribe Hilton Hotel than at the Ritz Carlton.



Now, let's look at the same sentences with the addition of transitional expressions.

- a. **First of all, the Caribe Hilton Hotel is located in a much better** place than its competitor, the Ritz Carlton.
- b. **In addition to its location, the Caribe Hilton offers better price** rates at all times.
- c. **Besides the location and the price rates, you will receive a far** better service at the Caribe Hilton Hotel than at the Ritz Carlton.

Select one of the topics below to develop an essay.

1. Choose two TV shows, magazines, or movies that you know well and compare or contrast them. If you select two items of the same type (two soap operas, two sports magazines), you would probably want to focus on differences. Comparisons are most effective with two items the reader would expect to be different, such as two different types of movies or TV shows.
2. Choose two entertainers, athletes, or leaders and compare/contrast them. You might want to use contrast to show that one provides a good example and the other does not. You might want to use comparison to show how two people who the reader would expect to be different have similar behaviors, attitudes, mannerisms, and so forth.

Sample Essay

“Whoever controls the media, controls the mind.”-Jim Morrison. In the course of recent events, two young girls from the suburbs of Lahore have instantly rose to fame. The cause of this fame was the fact that they could sing almost every Justin Bieber song in English, a language they have yet to learn. Consequently, both BBC News and Samaa News decided to cover their story of success in respective news reports. Even though the highlight of the news were the “Justin Biebies”, both broadcasting channels Samaa and BBC had a different approach when it came to presenting content, the tone of reporting and setting their broadcasting standards. Both channels represented the news quiet individually.

After viewing both reports of the same story, it was easy to distinguish the **content** of the two channels. At the beginning, BBC started off their report with the girls singing, which was the main subject of the entire story. **On the contrary**, Samaa News began with praising themselves for being the first to document the hidden talent of Pakistan and went on to play a clip of Justin Bieber's performance instead of showcasing the girls. The BBC **further** went on to explain the back story of the girls' fame and their passion for singing pop songs. **But** Samaa news focused more on the fact that the girls belonged to a working class and resided from the ghettos of Lahore, all of which had no relation to their talent at all. The report from the BBC concluded with the impact of fame on the girls' lives, leaving the viewer with an optimistic note. **However**, the Samaa report end with a Bollywood song, which took the focus away from the fact that the girls who had studied in Urdu their whole lives, sang in English. **What intrigued us the most was, how easy it was to differentiate the two reports, just by listening to the reporters.**

All news channels have a distinct **tone** to present different types of stories, this fact became more evident whilst viewing both news reports. BBC, being an international news agency, has a reputation for being formal in any situation. This was clear in the video clip when the reporter talked to the girls as if they were important personalities even though they were sitting outside their house. **On the other hand**, the Samaa reporter leaned towards the sarcastic side as if she was in disbelief of the fact that two girls from such a rural area could have such a talent inside them. In addition, the BBC appreciated the girls for the effort they made to learn not only the songs, but also the language. **However**, Samaa News seemed to make the news into a comical story by adding unnecessary animations. **Furthermore, the ways in which both channels opted to present the news could be clearly separated from one another.**

Lastly, the difference between the **broadcasting standards** of the **two channels** is a major standout. As we know, the Pakistani nation is quite an emotional one, so nationwide news channels from this as much as they can. In Samaa News, it could be seen how they deviated from the main news and thrived to sensationalize it to entice the audience, **whereas** when watching the BBC clip, you would realise that they meant nothing but business. They presented content in a very straight forward business manner. **As well as that**, the BBC reporter asked professional questions, being careful not to trespass personal boundaries. **On the other hand**, the reporter from Samaa news was seen scrutinizing the girls for details. **Moreover**, the authenticity of Samaa can be challenged, since the reporter can be seen presenting as if she is emotionally attached to the news. **However** the BBC reporter remained calm and maintained an even pace throughout the report.

In conclusion, there was a humongous difference in the way in which news is broadcasted between the international and local channels. Whilst the Western networks such as the BBC tend to keep their content professional, local channels lean towards sensationalising news in order to keep viewers interested. It seems like Pakistani channels still have a lot to learn from international media.